QUESTION 1
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Marine biologist Priya Naidu conducted a study examining coral bleaching events in the Andaman Sea. Naidu observed that certain coral species near volcanic vents, which are naturally exposed to slightly acidified water, showed greater resilience during thermal stress events compared to corals of the same species living farther from the vents. Naidu hypothesized that long-term exposure to mildly acidified conditions may enable some corals to develop a tolerance that also helps them withstand temperature increases.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Naidu's hypothesis?
A: Corals living near volcanic vents exhibited genetic markers associated with enhanced cellular stress responses, and these markers were absent in corals of the same species living in non-acidified waters.
B: Corals near volcanic vents were found to host a distinct variety of symbiotic algae that is more heat-resistant than the algae found in corals farther from the vents.
C: Water temperature near volcanic vents remained consistently lower than the temperature in surrounding areas, providing a cooler microhabitat for nearby coral colonies throughout the study period.
D: Several coral species not found near volcanic vents also demonstrated some degree of resilience during thermal stress events in the Andaman Sea, though at lower rates than vent-adjacent corals.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: The hypothesis claims acidification causes heat tolerance IN THE CORALS THEMSELVES. A shows a direct biological change (genetic markers) in vent corals that is absent in non-vent corals. B is tempting but shifts the mechanism to algae, not coral adaptation. C actually weakens by suggesting temperature, not acidification, explains resilience. D is irrelevant -- other species' resilience says nothing about acidification causing tolerance.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 2
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Economist Darren Whitfield studied wage patterns across twelve metropolitan areas in a developing nation from 2010 to 2020. Whitfield found that cities that had invested heavily in public transit infrastructure during the early part of the decade experienced a narrowing of income inequality by 2020, as measured by the Gini coefficient, compared to cities that had not made such investments. Whitfield proposed that improved public transit access enabled lower-income workers to reach higher-paying jobs that were previously inaccessible due to commuting constraints.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Whitfield's proposed explanation?
A: Workers in the highest income quartile in transit-invested cities showed no significant change in their commuting patterns between 2010 and 2020, suggesting that transit improvements primarily affected lower-income commuters.
B: Cities that invested in public transit also invested heavily in public education during the same period, producing a more skilled workforce across all income levels.
C: In cities with improved transit, the average commute time for workers in the lowest income quartile decreased by 35%, and these workers' wages grew at twice the rate of comparable workers in cities without transit improvements.
D: The Gini coefficient in cities without transit investment remained stable rather than increasing during the same period, indicating that inequality did not worsen in the absence of transit improvements.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: The explanation has two parts -- (1) transit enables access, (2) access leads to higher wages. C addresses BOTH parts by showing commute times fell AND wages rose for low-income workers specifically. A only shows high-income workers were unaffected, which doesn't prove the mechanism for low-income workers. D describes the control group but doesn't explain WHY transit helped.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 3
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Paleontologist Marcus Reeves analyzed fossilized pollen grains found in sedimentary layers at the Thornfield Basin in central Australia. Reeves noted that pollen from flowering plants first appears in a sedimentary layer dated to approximately 115 million years ago, replacing the conifer-dominated pollen record of earlier layers. Because flowering plants require insect pollinators to reproduce efficiently, Reeves concluded that a diverse insect pollinator community must have already been established in the Thornfield Basin region by 115 million years ago.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Reeves's conclusion?
A: Fossilized insect specimens found in the same sedimentary layer as the flowering plant pollen included several species with mouthparts suitable for pollen collection, but these species were also found in layers predating the flowering plants.
B: Multiple lineages of early flowering plants have been shown to reproduce effectively through wind pollination or self-pollination, and genetic analysis suggests these non-insect-dependent reproductive strategies were prevalent among early angiosperms.
C: Fossilized insect specimens found in the same sedimentary layer were predominantly predatory species, though trace evidence on some specimens suggested occasional contact with pollen-producing plants.
D: Flowering plant pollen from the same geological period has been found at multiple sites across Australia, some of which contained no fossilized insect remains whatsoever.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Reeves's conclusion rests on one KEY PREMISE: flowering plants require insect pollinators. If that premise is false -- if early flowering plants could reproduce without insects -- the conclusion collapses. B destroys this premise by showing early angiosperms used wind/self-pollination. C is tricky because predatory insects with pollen contact is ambiguous. D seems relevant but 'no insect remains' could just mean poor preservation.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 4
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Historian Elena Cabrera examined records from the colonial-era port city of San Venturo, which operated as a major trading hub from the sixteenth through eighteenth centuries. Cabrera found that merchant ledgers from the 1720s frequently listed goods such as Chinese porcelain, Indian textiles, and West African gold alongside locally produced sugar and tobacco. Cabrera argues that San Venturo served as a convergence point for global trade networks during this period.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Cabrera's argument?
A: The merchant ledgers were written in three different European languages, suggesting that merchants from multiple colonial powers operated in the port.
B: Sugar and tobacco were the two most valuable exports from the region during the 1720s and were traded primarily with European markets.
C: San Venturo's population grew rapidly between 1700 and 1730, making it one of the largest port cities in the region during that period.
D: Archaeological excavations in San Venturo uncovered residential artifacts from Chinese, Indian, and West African cultural traditions alongside European goods, confirming the presence of people from these diverse trade networks.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Cabrera claims San Venturo was a 'convergence point for global trade networks.' D provides PHYSICAL EVIDENCE of people from those exact networks living there. A shows European diversity but not global convergence. B only describes exports to Europe. Shortcut: match the claim's key word ('convergence') to the answer that shows multiple global networks actually meeting in one place.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 5
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Neuroscientist Kenji Yamamoto conducted a study in which participants were shown images of faces while undergoing functional magnetic resonance imaging (fMRI). Yamamoto observed that when participants viewed faces they rated as trustworthy, a region of the brain called the ventral striatum showed increased activity. Because the ventral striatum is associated with reward processing, Yamamoto concluded that perceiving someone as trustworthy triggers a reward response in the brain.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Yamamoto's conclusion?
A: A follow-up study found that the ventral striatum showed similar activation levels when participants viewed faces they rated as untrustworthy, provided those faces also displayed neutral expressions.
B: Participants' ratings of trustworthiness were consistent across two separate testing sessions conducted one week apart, indicating reliable measurement.
C: Participants who reported higher levels of general anxiety showed reduced ventral striatum activity across all experimental conditions, not just when viewing trustworthy faces.
D: The ventral striatum showed equally increased activity when participants viewed faces rated as physically attractive, regardless of perceived trustworthiness, and the faces rated as trustworthy were independently rated as significantly more attractive than those rated as untrustworthy.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Yamamoto says trustworthiness triggers reward. D shows two things: (1) the ventral striatum responds to attractiveness too, and (2) the 'trustworthy' faces happened to be more attractive. So the activation might be about ATTRACTIVENESS, not trustworthiness. This is a classic confounding variable. A is tempting but 'neutral expressions' changes the comparison. C is about anxiety, not the core link.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 6
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Political scientist Amara Osei studied voter turnout patterns in a West African nation that transitioned from paper ballots to electronic voting machines in selected districts between 2014 and 2022. Osei found that districts using electronic machines saw a 12% increase in voter turnout compared to districts that retained paper ballots. Osei hypothesized that the electronic machines reduced perceived barriers to voting for citizens with limited literacy, since the machines displayed candidate photographs and party symbols rather than requiring voters to read names on a ballot.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Osei's hypothesis?
A: Districts that switched to electronic voting also extended polling hours by two hours and increased the number of available polling stations during the same period.
B: The increase in voter turnout in electronic-voting districts was concentrated in rural areas where adult literacy rates were below 40%, while turnout in urban areas of the same districts remained largely unchanged.
C: A nationwide survey conducted in 2020 found that a majority of citizens expressed trust in the accuracy of electronic voting machines and preferred them over paper ballots.
D: Voter turnout in paper-ballot districts also increased during the same period, though by only 3%, suggesting a general upward trend in civic participation.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Osei's hypothesis is SPECIFICALLY about literacy barriers. B shows the turnout increase happened WHERE literacy was low -- rural areas below 40% literacy. Urban areas (higher literacy) saw no change. This is a dose-response match: the effect appears exactly where the proposed mechanism would predict.
A introduces a confound. C is about trust, not literacy.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 7
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Literary scholar Vanessa Okoro analyzed the novels of early twentieth-century Caribbean writer Clement St. Pierre. Okoro noted that St. Pierre consistently wrote dialogue in Creole patois while composing his narration in formal Standard English. Some critics have dismissed this as stylistic inconsistency, but Okoro argues that the deliberate contrast between narrative and dialogue registers was an intentional artistic strategy designed to highlight the cultural tensions between colonial authority and indigenous identity in St. Pierre's work.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Okoro's argument?
A: St. Pierre's novels were more commercially successful among Caribbean readers than among European readers during the period of their initial publication.
B: The Creole patois used in St. Pierre's dialogue is linguistically consistent with the dialect spoken in the specific region where the novels are set.
C: Letters from St. Pierre to his publisher reveal that the author insisted on preserving the Creole dialogue against his editor's repeated requests to standardize it into formal English, writing that the contrast was essential to his 'political project.'
D: Several other Caribbean writers of the same era also incorporated Creole dialect in their fiction, suggesting a broader regional literary movement.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Okoro argues the contrast was INTENTIONAL and DESIGNED to highlight colonial tensions. C provides direct authorial evidence: St. Pierre fought to keep the Creole and called it a 'political project.' This is the strongest type of evidence -- the author's own stated purpose. B shows accuracy but not intent. D shows a trend but doesn't prove individual intent.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 8
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Art historian Luisa Ferreira examined a collection of ceramic vessels excavated from a burial site in the Arequipa region of Peru, dating to approximately 600 CE. Ferreira noted that several vessels bore decorative motifs -- specifically, interlocking wave patterns and stylized condor imagery -- that are characteristic of the Huari culture, whose political center was located over 500 kilometers to the north. Ferreira concluded that the Huari exerted direct political control over the Arequipa region by 600 CE, using these artistic motifs as evidence of imperial administration.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Ferreira's conclusion?
A: Similar interlocking wave patterns and stylized condor imagery have been found on ceramics from multiple Andean cultures that had no known political ties to the Huari and predated Huari influence in the region.
B: The ceramic vessels found at the burial site were crafted using local clay and production techniques distinct from those used at the Huari political center, though the decorative motifs matched.
C: Archaeological evidence shows that obsidian, a commonly traded volcanic glass, was present at the burial site, suggesting the region participated in long-distance trade networks.
D: Written records from the Huari culture reference administrative outposts established in regions south of their political center during the sixth and seventh centuries.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Ferreira's logic is: Huari-style motifs found in Arequipa, therefore Huari controlled Arequipa. A breaks the link by showing those motifs AREN'T uniquely Huari -- other unrelated cultures used them too. If the motifs are widespread, they can't prove political control. B is tempting because local production methods could suggest independent creation, but the matching motifs are what Ferreira relies on. D actually supports Ferreira.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 9
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Microbiologist Fatima al-Rashid studied the gut microbiomes of two groups of laboratory mice. One group was raised in a standard laboratory environment, while the other was raised in an enriched environment with more space, novel objects, and social interaction opportunities. After twelve weeks, al-Rashid found that mice in the enriched environment had significantly greater microbial diversity in their digestive tracts. Al-Rashid proposed that the enriched environment stimulated greater exploratory behavior, leading the mice to encounter and ingest a wider variety of microorganisms from their surroundings, thereby increasing gut microbial diversity.

Which statement, if true, would most strongly support al-Rashid's proposed explanation?
A: Mice in the enriched environment consumed 15% more food per day than mice in the standard environment, and both groups were fed the same standardized diet throughout the twelve-week study.
B: Prior research has shown that increased social interaction among mice reduces stress hormones, which in turn may promote the growth of beneficial gut bacteria.
C: The standard laboratory mice showed a measurable decrease in gut microbial diversity over the twelve-week period compared to their baseline measurements at the start of the study.
D: Mice in the enriched environment spent three times as many hours exploring novel objects and different areas of their enclosures compared to mice in the standard environment, and many of the additional microbial species found in enriched-environment mice were also detected on surfaces within their enclosures.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: al-Rashid's explanation has a specific CAUSAL CHAIN: enrichment -> exploration -> ingestion of environmental microbes -> greater diversity. D confirms BOTH links: mice explored more AND the new microbes matched those on enclosure surfaces. B offers a COMPETING mechanism (stress hormones), which doesn't support al-Rashid's specific explanation. A is about food quantity, not exploration.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 10
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Sociologist Raymond Dupont surveyed residents of a mid-sized city and found that neighborhoods with more public parks had lower rates of reported loneliness among residents. Dupont concluded that access to public parks reduces loneliness by providing spaces where residents can form social connections with their neighbors.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Dupont's conclusion?
A: Several of the parks in the study were small pocket parks with limited seating and few amenities designed for group activities.
B: The neighborhoods with more parks were also wealthier, with higher rates of homeownership and more community organizations, compared to neighborhoods with fewer parks.
C: Loneliness rates in the city overall had decreased over the past decade, regardless of neighborhood characteristics or park availability.
D: A majority of park visitors surveyed reported that they typically visited parks alone rather than with friends or family members.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Dupont claims parks CAUSE less loneliness through social connections. B introduces a confounding variable: wealth. Wealthy neighborhoods may have both more parks AND less loneliness for reasons unrelated to parks (community organizations, homeownership, etc.). D is tempting -- visiting alone seems to weaken -- but people can still form connections with strangers at parks while visiting alone.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 11
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Art historian Jerome Batiste studied the later paintings of twentieth-century Trinidadian artist Marguerite Leclerc. Batiste noted that around 1965, Leclerc abruptly shifted from vibrant, multicolored canvases to a stark monochromatic palette using only shades of gray. While some critics have attributed this shift to financial constraints limiting her access to pigments, Batiste argues that the change was philosophically motivated -- Leclerc's personal journals from the period reveal her growing interest in existentialist thought, and Batiste contends that the monochromatic palette was her visual expression of existentialism's emphasis on the starkness of human experience.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Batiste's argument over the financial-constraints explanation?
A: Leclerc had studied briefly in Paris in the 1950s, where she was exposed to various European art movements, including existentialist theater.
B: Several of Leclerc's contemporaries in Trinidad also shifted to darker palettes during the 1960s, a period of political upheaval in the Caribbean.
C: Art critics at the time generally praised Leclerc's monochromatic works as among her strongest compositions, noting their 'philosophical depth.'
D: Financial records from Leclerc's gallery show that her paintings sold at higher prices after the shift to monochrome, and purchase receipts show she continued buying full-spectrum pigments throughout the 1960s and 1970s.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: The question asks you to support Batiste OVER the financial-constraints explanation. D does DOUBLE DUTY: it (1) refutes the financial explanation by showing she could afford and DID buy colored pigments, and (2) eliminates the financial motive since her income increased. A is tempting because Paris + existentialism seems relevant, but exposure alone doesn't prove motivation. B shifts to other artists. Shortcut: when a question says 'support X over Y,' look for the answer that simultaneously supports X and undermines Y.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 12
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Education researcher Tomoko Ishikawa analyzed standardized test scores from 200 schools across a large school district over a five-year period. Ishikawa found that schools which had adopted a 'flipped classroom' model -- in which students watch recorded lectures at home and complete practice exercises during class time -- showed an average improvement of 8 percentile points on standardized assessments compared to schools that maintained traditional instruction. Ishikawa concluded that the flipped classroom model is more effective than traditional instruction at improving student academic performance.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Ishikawa's conclusion?
A: Teachers at schools using the flipped classroom model reported spending more time preparing lessons than teachers at traditional-instruction schools, and teacher satisfaction surveys showed no significant difference between the two groups.
B: Students at schools using the flipped classroom model showed improvement on standardized assessments in both mathematics and reading, not just one subject area.
C: Schools that adopted the flipped classroom model had, on average, per-student technology budgets that were 40% higher than those of schools that maintained traditional instruction, and the additional funding was also used to hire supplementary tutoring staff.
D: The flipped classroom model was adopted at the recommendation of the district superintendent, and schools that adopted it received priority in subsequent rounds of grant funding.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Ishikawa claims the MODEL caused improvement. C shows the model-adopting schools ALSO had 40% more funding AND extra tutoring staff. The improvement could be from the money and tutors, not the model. This is a confounding variable -- the treatment group differs from the control in more ways than just the intervention. D is tricky because grant funding priority is ALSO a confound, but it refers to SUBSEQUENT funding, not concurrent support during the study.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 13
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Archaeologist Samuel Okafor discovered a series of iron tools at a dig site in the Nigerian savanna, dated to approximately 900 BCE. Okafor noted that the tools' composition and forging techniques closely resembled those used by ironworkers in the Nile Valley around the same period. Okafor concluded that ironworking knowledge was transmitted from the Nile Valley to West Africa through direct contact between the two regions.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the conclusion presented in the text?
A: Analysis of iron tools from several intermediate regions between the Nile Valley and the Nigerian savanna showed no evidence of similar forging techniques during the same period.
B: Iron ore deposits were abundant in both the Nigerian savanna and the Nile Valley during this period, making independent development of ironworking plausible.
C: Okafor's dig site also contained copper artifacts that predated the iron tools by several centuries, indicating a longer tradition of metalworking in the region.
D: The Nile Valley ironworking tradition continued to develop in sophistication after 900 BCE and eventually produced steel-quality implements.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Okafor claims DIRECT CONTACT transmitted knowledge from the Nile Valley to Nigeria. If direct contact occurred, you would expect to find similar techniques along the route between the two regions. A shows NO such evidence exists in the intermediate areas, undermining the 'direct contact' claim. B is tempting because it suggests independent development, but it only says independent development is PLAUSIBLE, not that it happened. C is a red herring about copper.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 14
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Ecologist Javier Morales studied the nesting behaviors of a species of tropical bird in a Costa Rican rainforest. Morales observed that these birds consistently built their nests near colonies of aggressive stinging ants. While other researchers had proposed that this nesting pattern was coincidental due to shared habitat preferences, Morales argued that the birds intentionally select nest sites near ant colonies because the ants deter predatory snakes that would otherwise consume the birds' eggs.

Which finding from the field study, if true, would most directly support Morales's argument over the alternative explanation?
A: Predatory snakes were found throughout the rainforest at roughly equal densities, regardless of the presence or absence of ant colonies.
B: In experimental trials where ant colonies near bird nests were removed, snake predation on eggs increased by 70% compared to control nests where ant colonies remained intact.
C: The species of stinging ant most commonly found near the birds' nests is one of the most abundant ant species in the Costa Rican rainforest, occupying a wide range of microhabitats.
D: The tropical birds in the study were observed feeding on various insects near their nests but were never observed consuming the stinging ants themselves.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: When two explanations compete (intentional selection vs. coincidence), the strongest evidence is an EXPERIMENT that isolates the proposed mechanism. B removes the ants and shows predation shoots up -- this directly proves the ants provide protection and suggests the birds benefit from proximity. A supports Morales somewhat but doesn't prove ants deter snakes. C actually supports the COMPETING hypothesis (shared habitat).
END QUESTION

QUESTION 15
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Psychologist Lena Bergstrom conducted a longitudinal study tracking 500 children from ages 3 to 18. Bergstrom found that children who participated in structured music lessons before age 7 scored, on average, 15% higher on measures of executive function at age 18 compared to children who did not receive music training. Bergstrom concluded that early music training enhances the development of executive function skills, which include planning, working memory, and cognitive flexibility.

Which statement, if true, would most directly weaken Bergstrom's conclusion?
A: Among children who began music lessons before age 7, those who continued lessons through age 18 scored higher on executive function measures than those who discontinued lessons before age 12.
B: Executive function skills have been shown to be moderately heritable, with genetic factors accounting for approximately 40% of variation among individuals.
C: Children who participated in structured sports training before age 7 did not show the same improvement in executive function scores at age 18.
D: Children whose parents enrolled them in music lessons before age 7 had parents who, on average, engaged in significantly more cognitively stimulating activities at home -- such as reading, puzzles, and educational games -- than the parents of children without music training.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Bergstrom claims music CAUSES better executive function. D offers a confounding variable: parents who enroll kids in music also provide more cognitive stimulation at home. The executive function advantage might come from the home environment, not the music itself. This is a SELF-SELECTION confound -- the families who choose music are systematically different. A actually strengthens by showing dose-response. B is about genetics generally, not this specific comparison.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 16
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Literary critic Adama Diallo studied the poetry of mid-twentieth-century Senegalese writer Ousmane Sow. Diallo noted that Sow's poems frequently employ images of baobab trees, seasonal rivers, and harmattan winds -- natural elements specific to the West African Sahel. Diallo argues that Sow used these landscape elements not merely as decoration but as central metaphors for resilience, impermanence, and endurance in postcolonial African life.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Diallo's argument?
A: Sow's poetry was more widely studied in African universities than in European ones during his lifetime.
B: The Sahel region experienced significant environmental changes during the mid-twentieth century, including prolonged droughts and desertification.
C: In a published interview, Sow stated that each natural image in his poetry was carefully chosen to represent a specific aspect of the human condition under colonialism and its aftermath, and he described the baobab as his symbol for cultural survival.
D: Several other Senegalese poets of the same era also used images of West African landscapes in their work, suggesting a shared literary tradition.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Diallo argues the images are INTENTIONAL METAPHORS, not decoration. The strongest evidence for intentional metaphor is the AUTHOR SAYING SO. C provides Sow's own words confirming deliberate symbolic use. D is tempting because a shared tradition could support the idea, but it doesn't prove Sow's individual intent. Shortcut: for 'deliberate strategy' claims, look for direct authorial evidence.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 17
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Linguist Daniela Costa studied the adoption of loanwords in a rural community in the Brazilian interior. Costa found that younger speakers (ages 15-25) used English-derived loanwords at three times the rate of older speakers (ages 55-65) in informal conversation. Costa proposed that increased access to social media platforms, which are predominantly English-language in their interface and trending content, has driven the higher rate of English loanword adoption among younger speakers.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Costa's proposed explanation?
A: Among speakers ages 15-25, those who reported using social media for more than three hours daily used English loanwords at significantly higher rates than those who reported using social media for less than one hour daily.
B: Younger speakers in urban areas of Brazil used English loanwords at even higher rates than younger speakers in the rural community Costa studied.
C: The English loanwords most frequently used by younger speakers were related to technology, food, and entertainment -- categories prominent on social media -- though similar terms also appear in television advertising.
D: Older speakers in the community had lower overall rates of internet access compared to younger speakers, though many reported watching English-language television programs.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Costa's explanation specifically names SOCIAL MEDIA as the driver. A provides a DOSE-RESPONSE relationship within the young age group: more social media use = more loanwords. This isolates social media as the variable. D is tempting because it shows an internet gap, but older speakers watching English TV muddles the picture. C mentions social media categories but also notes TV advertising has the same terms.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 18
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Astrophysicist Chen Wei analyzed spectroscopic data from a distant star system designated KR-7741. Chen observed periodic dimming events in the star's light output that occurred at regular 14-day intervals. Chen proposed that these dimming events are caused by a large, rocky exoplanet orbiting the star with a 14-day orbital period, passing between the star and Earth's line of sight during each orbit. Chen further argued that the depth and duration of the dimming events indicate the planet is approximately 1.5 times the diameter of Earth.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Chen's proposal?
A: The dimming events observed in KR-7741 are slightly asymmetric, with the dimming occurring more gradually at the beginning than at the end of each event.
B: Follow-up spectroscopic analysis revealed that the dimming events are accompanied by slight shifts in the star's spectral emission lines that are characteristic of stellar pulsations, not the gravitational effects of an orbiting companion.
C: Other stars of similar size and temperature to KR-7741 have been confirmed to host rocky exoplanets with orbital periods ranging from 10 to 20 days.
D: Radial velocity measurements of the star show a slight periodic variation, though the signal-to-noise ratio is too low to conclusively confirm or deny a planetary companion.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Chen says a planet causes the dimming. B provides an ALTERNATIVE
EXPLANATION: the star itself pulsates, causing periodic brightness changes. The spectral line shifts are characteristic of pulsations, NOT gravitational effects from a planet. A is tempting because asymmetry seems odd, but planetary transits can be asymmetric. D is deliberately tricky -- it neither confirms nor denies, so it doesn't weaken.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 19
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Nutritionist Aisha Obi conducted a study examining breakfast habits and academic performance among university students. Obi found that students who reported eating breakfast daily had grade point averages (GPAs) that were 0.3 points higher, on average, than students who reported skipping breakfast. Obi concluded that eating breakfast improves cognitive function and thereby enhances academic performance.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Obi's conclusion?
A: The students who reported eating breakfast came from a variety of academic disciplines and year levels, suggesting the pattern was consistent across contexts.
B: Students who ate breakfast daily also reported exercising more frequently than students who skipped breakfast, and exercise is independently linked to improved cognitive function.
C: Students who reported eating breakfast daily also reported getting more hours of sleep per night than students who skipped breakfast.
D: In a controlled experiment, students who were provided breakfast before a standardized cognitive test scored significantly higher on measures of attention and memory than students who were given no breakfast, with all other conditions held constant.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Obi's study is CORRELATIONAL (breakfast eaters have higher GPAs), but her conclusion is CAUSAL (breakfast improves cognition). D provides a CONTROLLED EXPERIMENT that isolates breakfast as the variable. This is the gold standard for supporting a causal claim from correlational data. B and C are tempting but they are actually CONFOUNDING VARIABLES that weaken the claim. Shortcut: when a correlational study makes a causal claim, the best support is always an experiment.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 20
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Volcanologist Sandra Mbeki analyzed gas emissions from a chain of dormant volcanoes in eastern Tanzania. Mbeki noted that sulfur dioxide (SO2) emissions from one volcano, designated Mount Kigongo, had increased threefold over the past decade. Mbeki concluded that magma is actively rising beneath Mount Kigongo and that the volcano may be transitioning from dormancy to an active phase, potentially leading to an eruption within the next century.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Mbeki's conclusion?
A: Seismic monitoring stations near Mount Kigongo have detected no increase in earthquake frequency or intensity over the past decade, and ground deformation measurements show no uplift consistent with rising magma.
B: Geological surveys have determined that Mount Kigongo last erupted approximately 40,000 years ago, making it one of the longest-dormant volcanoes in the chain.
C: Two other dormant volcanoes in the same chain have also shown slight increases in SO2 emissions over the same period, though neither has shown the threefold increase observed at Mount Kigongo.
D: SO2 emissions from an active volcano in a different region of Tanzania have been decreasing over the past decade.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Mbeki says rising magma causes the SO2. If magma were truly rising, you would expect TWO other indicators: more earthquakes and ground uplift. A shows NEITHER is present. This means the SO2 increase likely has a different cause (e.g., changes in groundwater chemistry). C is tempting because regional SO2 increases suggest a non-magma explanation, but the question asks what MOST DIRECTLY weakens. A eliminates the expected physical evidence of rising magma.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 21
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Literary historian Marguerite Pellerin examined correspondence between French salon hostesses in the 1770s and 1780s. Pellerin found that several hostesses exchanged letters discussing the philosophical writings of male contemporaries, often critiquing arguments and proposing counterarguments of considerable sophistication. Pellerin argues that these salonieres were not merely passive facilitators of intellectual exchange, as traditional scholarship has suggested, but were active contributors to Enlightenment philosophical discourse whose ideas influenced the male philosophers who attended their salons.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Pellerin's argument?
A: The salonieres' correspondence demonstrates familiarity with classical Greek and Latin philosophical texts, indicating that these women received a rigorous intellectual education.
B: The number of active salons in Paris increased substantially between 1770 and 1789, suggesting growing public interest in intellectual gatherings among the upper classes.
C: Several philosophical treatises published by male attendees of the salons contain arguments and phrasings that closely echo ideas first articulated in the salonieres' private correspondence, and the correspondence predates the treatises by months or years.
D: Male philosophers who attended the salons acknowledged in their published works that the salon environment was conducive to productive debate and intellectual refinement.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Pellerin claims the women INFLUENCED the male philosophers. C provides the strongest possible evidence: the men's published works contain ideas that appeared FIRST in the women's letters (with the chronology proving direction of influence). A shows the women were educated but not that they influenced others. D says men acknowledged the ENVIRONMENT was helpful, not that the WOMEN'S ideas shaped their work.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 22
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Film critic Nikolai Petrov studied the visual style of Estonian director Kaisa Tamm, whose films are characterized by long, static shots and muted color grading. Petrov noted that Tamm studied under renowned Hungarian director Laszlo Varga for two years in Budapest. Petrov concluded that Tamm's visual style was primarily shaped by Varga's mentorship, since Varga's own films are known for similarly slow pacing and restrained color palettes.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Petrov's conclusion?
A: Tamm has cited Japanese cinema, particularly the films of Yasujiro Ozu, as a major influence on her work in several published interviews.
B: Tamm's earliest short films, which were completed before she studied with Varga, already featured long static shots and muted color grading virtually identical to the style of her later work.
C: Several other directors who studied under Varga did not adopt his visual style in their own films, suggesting that Varga's mentorship did not consistently produce stylistic followers.
D: Varga's films have been praised by critics for their emotional depth and narrative complexity in addition to their distinctive visual style.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Petrov claims Varga's mentorship SHAPED Tamm's style. B uses CHRONOLOGY to destroy this: Tamm already had the style before studying with Varga. If the effect existed before the supposed cause, the cause can't be responsible. A is tempting because it offers another influence, but multiple influences can coexist -- it doesn't eliminate Varga's. C is about OTHER students, not Tamm.
Shortcut: timeline evidence is the most powerful way to weaken a causal claim.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 23
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Urban planner Kwame Asante studied traffic congestion patterns in three African capital cities that implemented congestion pricing -- charging drivers a fee to enter central business districts during peak hours. Asante found that all three cities experienced a 20-30% reduction in peak-hour vehicle entries within the first year. However, Asante also observed that total daily vehicle entries remained largely unchanged. Asante proposed that congestion pricing primarily shifts driving behavior from peak to off-peak hours rather than reducing overall vehicle usage.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Asante's proposal?
A: GPS tracking data from vehicles in the three cities showed that the same drivers who previously entered the central district during peak hours increasingly entered during off-peak hours after congestion pricing was implemented.
B: Average vehicle speeds in the central business districts during peak hours increased by 15% after congestion pricing was implemented, indicating less traffic during those periods.
C: Public transit ridership in all three cities increased by approximately 10% in the year following the implementation of congestion pricing.
D: Revenue from congestion pricing exceeded initial government projections in all three cities during the first year, due to higher-than-expected off-peak entries.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Asante's proposal is specifically that drivers SHIFTED from peak to off-peak hours. A provides direct GPS evidence that the SAME DRIVERS changed their timing. C is the trickiest distractor -- transit ridership increase suggests some drivers SWITCHED MODES (drove less, rode transit more), which is the OPPOSITE of Asante's claim. D mentions off-peak entries but doesn't prove it's the SAME drivers who shifted.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 24
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Geneticist Yuki Tanaka studied a population of wild foxes on an isolated island off the coast of Japan. Tanaka observed that the island fox population exhibited remarkably low genetic diversity compared to mainland fox populations. Tanaka noted that the island was connected to the mainland by a land bridge until approximately 8,000 years ago, when rising sea levels severed the connection. Tanaka concluded that the low genetic diversity is the result of a 'founder effect' -- a small number of foxes were isolated on the island when the land bridge submerged, and the limited gene pool of these founders has persisted.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Tanaka's conclusion?
A: The island currently supports a fox population of approximately 300 individuals, which genetic modeling suggests is sufficient to maintain moderate genetic diversity over thousands of years under normal conditions.
B: Other mammal species on the island, such as rabbits and shrews, also show lower genetic diversity than their mainland counterparts.
C: The land bridge that once connected the island to the mainland was approximately 12 kilometers wide, suggesting that substantial animal migration could have occurred before it submerged.
D: Fossil evidence indicates that a large and genetically diverse fox population inhabited the island as recently as 2,000 years ago, but a volcanic eruption approximately 1,500 years ago caused a catastrophic population decline.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Tanaka says low diversity comes from the founder effect 8,000 years ago. D destroys this by showing the population was LARGE AND DIVERSE just 2,000 years ago -- long after the land bridge submerged. A volcanic eruption 1,500 years ago provides an ALTERNATIVE explanation for the low diversity. C is tempting because a wide bridge suggests many founders, but this only weakens the founder effect slightly. D provides both a timeline contradiction AND an alternative cause.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 25
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Chemist Ingrid Paulsson developed a new polymer coating designed to reduce ice accumulation on wind turbine blades in Arctic conditions. In laboratory tests, Paulsson found that blades coated with her polymer accumulated 60% less ice than uncoated blades when exposed to freezing fog at -15 degrees C for 24 hours. Paulsson proposed that the coating works by creating a surface with extremely low water adhesion, causing water droplets to roll off before they freeze.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Paulsson's proposed mechanism?
A: The polymer coating maintained its effectiveness through 500 freeze-thaw cycles in laboratory testing without significant degradation.
B: High-speed camera footage revealed that water droplets contacting the coated surface rolled off within 0.3 seconds on average, while droplets on uncoated surfaces remained in place for over 5 seconds before freezing.
C: The polymer coating also reduced dust accumulation on the blade surface by approximately 40% compared to uncoated blades, suggesting broadly reduced surface adhesion.
D: Wind turbine blades in Arctic conditions typically lose 10-20% of their energy production capacity due to ice accumulation during winter months.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Paulsson's proposed mechanism is specific: low water adhesion causes droplets to ROLL OFF before freezing. B directly OBSERVES this mechanism in action with high-speed cameras. A shows the coating lasts but doesn't explain how it works. C is tempting because dust reduction also suggests low adhesion, but the question asks about the ICE mechanism specifically. Shortcut: when the claim is about a mechanism, look for the answer that directly observes that mechanism operating.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 26
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Anthropologist Maria Gutierrez studied a rural community in Guatemala where handwoven textiles are a significant cultural tradition. Gutierrez observed that the number of active weavers in the community had declined by 50% over the past twenty years and that younger community members showed little interest in learning the craft. Gutierrez concluded that the tradition of handweaving is disappearing because younger generations prefer modern factory-made clothing.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the claim about the decline in handweaving that is presented in the text?
A: Older weavers in the community reported that the quality of locally available weaving materials had declined substantially over time, making the craft more difficult to practice.
B: The cost of factory-made clothing in the region had decreased by 30% over the past two decades due to increased imports from Asian manufacturing centers.
C: A survey of younger community members revealed that most valued handweaving as a cultural tradition but could not afford the time to learn, since they needed to work in nearby cities for wages to support their families.
D: Handwoven textiles from the community are sold at regional markets to tourists who value their cultural significance, and demand has increased in recent years.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Gutierrez says decline is because young people PREFER factory clothing. C directly contradicts this: young people actually VALUE handweaving but face ECONOMIC CONSTRAINTS (they need wage labor). The cause isn't preference -- it's necessity. B is tempting because cheaper factory clothing seems to support the preference explanation, but lower prices don't prove people prefer the product. A provides an alternative reason (material quality) but doesn't address young people's preferences.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 27
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Zoologist Emma Lindqvist studied migratory patterns of a species of Arctic tern that breeds on the northern coast of Norway. Using lightweight GPS trackers attached to 40 birds, Lindqvist found that instead of following the expected coastal route southward along western Africa, approximately 30% of the tracked terns flew an inland route across the Sahara Desert. Lindqvist proposed that these inland-route birds exploit high-altitude wind currents over the Sahara that significantly reduce the energy cost of their migration.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Lindqvist's proposal?
A: Atmospheric data collected during the migration period confirmed the presence of consistent high-altitude tailwinds over the Sahara, and the inland-route terns' recorded flight altitudes matched the altitude of these winds.
B: The inland-route terns arrived at their wintering grounds in southern Africa an average of six days earlier than the coastal-route terns despite traveling a comparable total distance.
C: Inland-route terns were observed making brief stops at oases in the Sahara to rest and drink water before continuing their journey southward.
D: The body mass of inland-route terns at the beginning of the migration was not significantly different from that of coastal-route terns, ruling out physical differences as an explanation for route choice.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Lindqvist says inland birds use high-altitude tailwinds. A provides TWO pieces of evidence: (1) tailwinds exist over the Sahara, and (2) the birds flew at the exact altitude where those winds are. This matches the mechanism perfectly. B is tempting because arriving earlier could result from tailwinds, but it could also result from a shorter route, fewer stops, etc. -- it doesn't isolate the wind mechanism.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 28
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Economist Patricia Novak studied the relationship between remote work adoption and commercial real estate prices in twelve major US cities between 2020 and 2025. Novak found that cities with higher rates of remote work adoption experienced larger declines in commercial office space prices. Novak concluded that remote work is the primary driver of declining commercial real estate values in these cities, predicting that further increases in remote work will continue to depress prices.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Novak's conclusion?
A: Several companies in cities with high remote work adoption rates announced plans to require employees to return to the office full-time by 2026.
B: The average square footage of commercial office space leased per employee has decreased across all twelve cities regardless of remote work adoption rates.
C: Residential real estate prices in the same twelve cities showed varied trends, with some cities experiencing increases and others experiencing decreases during the same period.
D: The cities with the highest rates of remote work adoption were also the cities most affected by a simultaneous increase in municipal property taxes and a decline in local economic activity due to the departure of major corporate headquarters.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Novak claims remote work is the PRIMARY driver of price declines. D provides CONFOUNDING VARIABLES: tax increases and corporate departures hit the same cities hardest. If multiple factors aligned in the same cities, you can't isolate remote work as the primary cause. A is tempting but discusses FUTURE plans, not what caused the past decline. B shows a nationwide trend unrelated to remote work rates, which could slightly weaken but is less direct than D.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 29
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Literary scholar Reiko Hashimoto studied the novels of early twentieth-century Japanese author Taro Murasaki. Hashimoto observed that Murasaki's later novels frequently shift between first-person and third-person narration within the same chapter, sometimes mid-paragraph. While some critics have called this technique careless or confusing, Hashimoto argues that the shifts are a deliberate narrative strategy designed to blur the boundary between a character's subjective experience and objective reality, reflecting Murasaki's interest in the unreliability of personal perception.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Hashimoto's argument?
A: Contemporary reviewers of Murasaki's work described his prose style as innovative but challenging, and several noted that the narration shifts seemed to occur at unpredictable moments.
B: Drafts of Murasaki's novels show that he revised passages multiple times to ensure that the narration shifts occurred at moments when characters' perceptions of events diverged from what other characters experienced.
C: Narration shifts between first and third person are common in Japanese fiction published during the early twentieth century, reflecting broader literary experimentation.
D: Murasaki's earliest novels, written before his interest in perception developed, use exclusively third-person narration throughout.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Hashimoto claims the shifts are DELIBERATE and designed to blur subjective/ objective boundaries. B shows Murasaki REVISED drafts to place shifts at specific moments (when perceptions diverge). Revision = deliberate. Placement at perception-divergence moments = confirms the purpose Hashimoto identifies. D is tempting because it shows a change over time, but changing one's style doesn't prove the reason. Shortcut: for 'deliberate strategy' claims, drafts/revisions are the strongest evidence type.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 30
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Historian James Thornton studied the decline of a medieval trading settlement called Westmark, which was abandoned around 1350 CE. Thornton found that the settlement's main well showed signs of contamination with heavy metals. Thornton concluded that the contaminated water supply was the primary reason the inhabitants abandoned Westmark.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Thornton's conclusion?
A: Several other medieval settlements in the same region were also abandoned around 1350 CE, a period associated with the Black Death pandemic in Europe.
B: The heavy metal contamination in the well was later determined to have originated from natural mineral deposits in the bedrock rather than human activity.
C: Archaeological evidence shows that the inhabitants of Westmark relied primarily on a nearby river, not the well, for their drinking water, and the well appears to have been used mainly for livestock and irrigation.
D: Westmark's population had been growing steadily in the century before its abandonment, suggesting the settlement was thriving until relatively shortly before 1350 CE.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Thornton says contaminated water supply drove abandonment. C breaks the causal link by showing the inhabitants DIDN'T RELY ON THE WELL for drinking water. If they used the river instead, well contamination couldn't have been the primary reason to leave. A is tempting because the Black Death offers a competing explanation, but it doesn't DIRECTLY address the water claim. B seems relevant but natural contamination is still contamination -- the source doesn't change the health impact.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 31
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Physicist Ravi Chakraborty observed that a particular ceramic compound, barium-strontium titanate (BST), exhibited a sharp increase in its dielectric constant when cooled below -40 degrees C. While previous research had attributed this transition to a structural phase change in the crystal lattice, Chakraborty proposed an alternative explanation: that nanoscale clusters of polar molecules within the ceramic become cooperatively aligned at low temperatures, creating localized ferroelectric domains that collectively amplify the material's dielectric response without any change to the overall crystal structure.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Chakraborty's alternative explanation over the established view?
A: X-ray diffraction analysis of BST at temperatures above and below -40 degrees C revealed no detectable change in the crystal lattice parameters, while transmission electron microscopy at temperatures below -40 degrees C revealed the emergence of nanoscale regions with uniform molecular alignment.
B: Computational models predict that BST should undergo a structural phase change at approximately -40 degrees C based on the material's known atomic composition.
C: The dielectric constant of BST returns to its original value when the material is reheated above -40 degrees C, demonstrating that the transition is fully reversible.
D: Other ceramic compounds with similar crystal structures also exhibit increases in dielectric constant at low temperatures, though the transition temperatures vary.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: The question asks you to support Chakraborty OVER the established view. Chakraborty says: no structural change + nanoscale polar alignment. A provides evidence for BOTH halves: X-ray shows no lattice change (contradicting the established view), and electron microscopy shows nanoscale alignment (confirming Chakraborty's mechanism). B actually supports the OLD explanation. C is neutral -- reversibility fits either model. Shortcut: when asked to support X over Y, the best answer both supports X AND undermines Y.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 32
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Psychologist Martin Ekstrom studied the effect of background music on reading comprehension. In his study, university students who read passages while listening to classical music scored an average of 12% higher on comprehension questions than students who read in silence. Ekstrom concluded that listening to classical music enhances reading comprehension.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Ekstrom's conclusion?
A: Previous studies on the relationship between music and cognitive performance have produced mixed results, with some finding benefits and others finding no effect.
B: Students in the music group reported finding the classical music pleasant and relaxing, which some researchers associate with improved cognitive performance.
C: The passages used in the study covered topics from multiple academic disciplines, including science, history, and literature.
D: Students in the music group were volunteers who self-selected into the condition, and they reported significantly higher baseline reading comprehension scores than students in the silent group before the study began.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Ekstrom claims music CAUSES better comprehension. D shows the music group already had higher comprehension scores BEFORE the study. This is a SELECTION BIAS: better readers chose the music condition, so the 12% difference may reflect pre-existing ability, not the music's effect. A is tempting but prior mixed results don't weaken THIS study's conclusion. Shortcut: in any study, ask 'were the groups equivalent at the start?' If not, the comparison is unfair.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 33
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Botanist Hiroshi Nakamura observed that a species of orchid found in cloud forests of Southeast Asia produces flowers with an unusually long nectar spur -- a tube-like extension of the petal that contains nectar. Nakamura measured spur lengths averaging 12 centimeters, far longer than the spurs of related orchid species. Nakamura concluded that the species co-evolved with a specific moth pollinator that has a correspondingly long proboscis, as Darwin famously predicted for a similar orchid in Madagascar.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Nakamura's conclusion?
A: The orchid species produces a strong fragrance at night, which is a common trait of moth-pollinated flowers across multiple plant families.
B: Field observations over three flowering seasons recorded no moth visits to the orchid; instead, the flowers were exclusively pollinated by small birds that inserted their beaks into the opening of the spur without reaching the bottom.
C: DNA analysis indicated that the orchid species diverged from its closest relatives approximately 3 million years ago, a timeframe sufficient for co-evolutionary adaptation.
D: Other orchid species in the same cloud forest also have elongated nectar spurs, though none as long as Nakamura's study species.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Nakamura claims co-evolution with a moth. B provides DIRECT OBSERVATIONAL EVIDENCE that no moths visit the flowers -- birds do instead. If moths never visit, the orchid couldn't have co-evolved with them. The long spur has a different explanation (birds inserting beaks). A is deliberately tricky: nighttime fragrance SUPPORTS moth pollination and thus supports Nakamura's claim. Always check whether a distractor actually weakens or strengthens.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 34
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Archaeologist Diane Okonkwo analyzed the remains of a large stone structure at a site in the Niger River valley, dated to approximately 1100 CE. The structure featured thick walls, narrow windows, and a centralized courtyard accessible through a single reinforced entrance. Okonkwo concluded that the structure served a military defensive purpose, functioning as a fortification or garrison during a period of regional conflict between rival chieftaindoms.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the conclusion about the structure's purpose that is presented in the text?
A: The stone used in the structure was quarried from a source approximately 50 kilometers from the site, suggesting significant labor investment.
B: Similar thick-walled structures from the same period have been found at other sites in West Africa, some of which are confirmed fortifications and others which remain unidentified in purpose.
C: Analysis of soil samples from the courtyard revealed high concentrations of grain residue and remnants of large ceramic storage vessels, while no arrowheads, weapon fragments, or other military artifacts were found anywhere on the site.
D: Oral histories from communities in the region describe a period of peace and cooperative trade among chieftaindoms around 1100 CE, though oral traditions may not preserve all historical conflicts.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Okonkwo says the structure was military. C provides TWO types of evidence against this: (1) POSITIVE evidence for non-military use (grain storage), and (2) NEGATIVE evidence against military use (no weapons found). Together these strongly suggest the structure was for storage, not defense. D is tempting because peace undermines the need for a garrison, but oral histories are acknowledged as potentially incomplete. C provides direct physical evidence. Shortcut: physical evidence from the site itself is stronger than external historical accounts.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 35
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Musicologist Fiona Achebe studied the compositions of mid-twentieth-century Nigerian pianist and composer Nkem Adichie. Achebe noted that several of Adichie's piano sonatas incorporate rhythmic patterns and melodic intervals that closely resemble traditional Igbo folk songs. While some scholars have attributed these similarities to coincidence, Achebe argues that Adichie deliberately integrated Igbo musical traditions into Western classical forms as a means of cultural preservation and synthesis.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Achebe's argument?
A: Adichie's personal notebooks contain detailed transcriptions of Igbo folk songs alongside annotations describing how she planned to adapt specific rhythmic and melodic elements for use in her sonatas.
B: Adichie's sonatas were performed more frequently at concert halls in Lagos than in London during the 1960s and 1970s.
C: Adichie studied classical piano at a conservatory in London before returning to Nigeria, where she composed most of her major works.
D: Igbo folk songs share certain rhythmic characteristics with folk music from other West African cultures, including Yoruba and Hausa traditions.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Achebe claims DELIBERATE integration. A provides direct evidence from Adichie's own notebooks showing she (1) transcribed Igbo folk songs and (2) annotated how to adapt them for her sonatas. This is the clearest possible evidence of intentional incorporation. Shortcut: for 'deliberate' or 'intentional' claims, the strongest support is always documentation of the creator's own planning process.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 36
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Criminologist Laura Hendricks studied crime rates in eight neighborhoods that had installed streetlight upgrades -- replacing dim, yellow sodium lamps with brighter, white LED lighting. Hendricks found that reported crime rates decreased by an average of 18% in the year following the upgrades. Hendricks concluded that brighter street lighting deters criminal activity by increasing the perceived risk of detection among potential offenders.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Hendricks's conclusion?
A: Residents of the upgraded neighborhoods reported feeling safer after the lighting changes, according to a post-installation survey conducted by the city.
B: The LED lights consumed 40% less electricity than the sodium lamps they replaced, resulting in significant cost savings for the municipalities.
C: Crime rates in the eight neighborhoods had been declining steadily for three years before the streetlight upgrades were installed.
D: The streetlight upgrades were part of a broader neighborhood revitalization initiative that also included increased police patrols, security camera installations, and community watch programs in the same neighborhoods during the same period.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Hendricks claims brighter lighting CAUSED the crime decrease. D shows the lighting was part of a PACKAGE of interventions (police, cameras, community watch). If multiple interventions happened simultaneously, you can't attribute the crime reduction to lighting alone. C is tempting because a pre-existing decline suggests the decrease might have continued without lighting, but D is more direct because it provides specific concurrent interventions that could explain the change.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 37
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Oceanographer Mei-Ling Zhou discovered an unusual deep-ocean current in the South Pacific that flows in the opposite direction of the overlying surface current. While conventional oceanographic models attribute deep currents to differences in water density caused by temperature and salinity variations (thermohaline circulation), Zhou proposed that this particular countercurrent is driven primarily by the topography of an undersea ridge system. According to Zhou's model, the ridge system channels water through narrow gaps, accelerating and redirecting the flow in ways that thermohaline forces alone cannot explain.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Zhou's topography-driven model over the conventional thermohaline explanation?
A: The undersea ridge system in the South Pacific was formed by volcanic activity approximately 20 million years ago and extends for over 3,000 kilometers.
B: Measurements revealed that the temperature and salinity of the water in the countercurrent were nearly identical to those of the surrounding deep water, while the current intensified dramatically where the ridge system narrowed and weakened where the ridge system widened.
C: Satellite-derived measurements of sea surface height in the region showed patterns consistent with deep-water circulation anomalies.
D: Other deep-ocean countercurrents in the Atlantic Ocean have been conclusively attributed to thermohaline circulation patterns.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: The question asks support for topography OVER thermohaline. B provides evidence against thermohaline (temperature and salinity are the SAME, so density differences can't drive the current) AND evidence for topography (current speed tracks ridge width). D is a trap: other Atlantic currents being thermohaline actually supports the conventional model, not Zhou's. Shortcut: when asked 'support X over Y,' look for the answer that undermines Y's mechanism AND confirms X's mechanism in one stroke.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 38
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Education researcher Nadia Kourani observed that students at a secondary school in Beirut who took notes by hand during lectures performed better on end-of-semester exams than students who typed their notes on laptops. Kourani proposed that handwriting forces students to paraphrase and summarize information in real time -- since they cannot write as fast as the lecturer speaks -- and this processing leads to deeper understanding and better retention.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Kourani's proposed explanation?
A: The average study time reported by both groups in preparation for end-of-semester exams was approximately the same.
B: Students who took notes by hand reported that they found the lectures more engaging than students who typed their notes on laptops.
C: Analysis of the notes revealed that handwriting students' notes contained fewer verbatim phrases from the lectures and more original summaries compared to laptop users, who tended to transcribe the lecturer's words directly.
D: The students who took notes by hand and the students who typed were enrolled in different sections of the same course, taught by different instructors using the same curriculum.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Kourani's mechanism is specific: handwriting forces PARAPHRASING and SUMMARIZING, which leads to deeper understanding. C provides direct evidence that handwriters DID paraphrase (fewer verbatim phrases, more summaries) while typers DID transcribe (verbatim copying). This confirms the mechanism is operating. A controls for study time but doesn't address paraphrasing. B is about engagement, which is a different explanation entirely.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 39
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Astrobiologist Sandra Kepler analyzed soil samples collected by a rover from a dry lakebed on Mars. The samples contained mineral formations that on Earth are typically produced by microbial activity in shallow water environments. Kepler concluded that the mineral formations constitute evidence that microbial life once existed on Mars.

Which choice, if true, would most directly weaken Kepler's conclusion?
A: Laboratory experiments demonstrated that the same mineral formations can be produced by purely chemical processes under conditions of high ultraviolet radiation and low atmospheric pressure -- conditions that characterize the Martian surface.
B: None of the soil samples contained organic carbon compounds, which are considered essential building blocks of life on Earth.
C: The dry lakebed where the samples were collected is estimated to have contained liquid water approximately 3.5 billion years ago.
D: Mineral formations produced by microbial activity on Earth have been found in a wide range of environments, including hot springs, ocean floors, and desert lakes.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Kepler claims the minerals prove microbial life. A provides an ALTERNATIVE EXPLANATION: the same minerals form through CHEMISTRY, no life needed, under Mars-like conditions specifically. B is tempting -- no organic carbon seems to weaken -- but organic carbon could have degraded over billions of years. A is stronger because it directly shows the minerals can form without life. Shortcut: for 'evidence of X,' the strongest weakener is always 'the same evidence can exist without X.'
END QUESTION

QUESTION 40
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Sociologist Fatou Diallo studied the effects of microfinance loans on women's economic empowerment in rural Senegal. Diallo found that women who received microfinance loans were more likely to report making independent household spending decisions five years later than women who did not receive loans. However, some scholars have argued that the observed difference is due to self-selection: women who seek out microfinance loans may already possess traits -- such as higher self-confidence or ambition -- that predispose them to greater economic autonomy, regardless of whether they receive a loan.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Diallo's conclusion that the loans themselves contributed to women's economic empowerment, rather than the self-selection explanation?
A: The microfinance organization that provided the loans also offered financial literacy workshops to all loan recipients, and workshop attendance was positively correlated with increases in independent decision-making.
B: Women who received loans were more likely to have attended primary school than women who did not receive loans.
C: Women who received larger loans showed greater gains in independent decision-making than women who received smaller loans.
D: Among women who applied for microfinance loans, those whose applications were approved showed significantly greater increases in independent decision-making than those whose applications were rejected due to administrative capacity constraints unrelated to the applicants' characteristics.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: The self-selection argument says loan-seekers are already different. D controls for this by comparing WITHIN the applicant pool: all women applied (same motivation), but some were rejected for ADMINISTRATIVE reasons (nothing to do with their traits). This creates a natural experiment. If approved applicants still did better, the loan itself must have helped. C is tempting (dose-response) but doesn't address self-selection. B actually supports the self-selection critique.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 41
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Agronomist David Park conducted a two-year field study comparing crop yields on farms that used synthetic fertilizers with farms that used organic compost. Park found that farms using organic compost produced 15% higher yields of tomatoes per hectare. Park concluded that organic compost is more effective than synthetic fertilizers at increasing tomato crop yields.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Park's conclusion?
A: Park's study was funded by a regional agricultural cooperative that promotes organic farming methods.
B: The farms using organic compost were located in a region with richer natural soil and more favorable rainfall patterns than the farms using synthetic fertilizers.
C: Organic compost is more expensive per unit than synthetic fertilizer in most agricultural markets, making it less accessible to small-scale farmers.
D: The farms using synthetic fertilizers had been in operation for an average of ten years longer than the farms using organic compost, potentially affecting soil depletion levels.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Park compared two groups of farms and attributed the yield difference to the fertilizer type. B shows the groups differed in a critical way: SOIL AND RAINFALL. Better soil and rain alone could explain higher yields, regardless of fertilizer type. D is also a confound (older farms may have depleted soil), but it requires an extra inferential step. B is more direct. Shortcut: in observational studies, always ask 'what else differed between the groups?'
END QUESTION

QUESTION 42
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Sociologist Ren Watanabe examined patterns of charitable giving among residents of a large Japanese city. Watanabe found that residents who reported having at least three close friends in their neighborhood donated an average of 40% more to local charities than residents who reported having fewer than three close neighborhood friends. Watanabe proposed that strong local social networks increase charitable giving because individuals feel greater social pressure to contribute when their peers are also contributing and can observe their behavior.

Which statement, if true, would most strongly support Watanabe's proposed explanation?
A: Residents who reported having at least three close friends in their neighborhood also reported higher household incomes than those with fewer neighborhood friends.
B: The local charities that received the most donations were those that had been operating in the community for the longest period of time.
C: Residents with strong local social networks donated more to local charities -- where their contributions would be visible to neighbors -- but showed no difference in donations to anonymous online charitable campaigns compared to residents with weaker networks.
D: Residents who had recently moved to the neighborhood donated less to local charities on average than long-term residents, regardless of their number of close friends.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Watanabe says social PRESSURE (peers observing your behavior) drives giving. C tests this by comparing VISIBLE giving (local charities) vs. ANONYMOUS giving (online). If the effect only appears when giving is visible, that's strong evidence for social pressure. A is a trap -- higher income is a confounding variable that actually WEAKENS the conclusion. D is about tenure/familiarity, not the specific pressure mechanism.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 43
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Neuroscientist Arjun Malhotra studied patients with damage to the anterior cingulate cortex (ACC), a brain region associated with error monitoring and conflict resolution. Malhotra found that patients with ACC damage performed normally on simple decision-making tasks but showed significant impairment on tasks requiring them to override a habitual response in favor of an alternative response. Malhotra concluded that the ACC is essential specifically for cognitive control -- the ability to suppress automatic responses and execute goal-directed behavior -- rather than for general decision-making.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Malhotra's conclusion?
A: Patients with ACC damage also showed significant impairment on sustained attention tasks that did not require overriding habitual responses but instead required maintaining focus over extended periods without breaks.
B: Other brain regions, including the dorsolateral prefrontal cortex, have also been associated with cognitive control functions in prior neuroimaging studies.
C: The tasks requiring override of habitual responses were significantly more difficult overall than the simple decision-making tasks, as measured by the performance of healthy control participants.
D: Neuroimaging studies of healthy individuals showed that the ACC was activated during both simple decision-making tasks and tasks requiring cognitive control, with no significant difference in activation levels between the two task types.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Malhotra claims the ACC is SPECIFICALLY for cognitive control (overriding habits), NOT general decision-making. A undermines this specificity: ACC patients also failed at sustained attention, which is NOT cognitive control (no habitual response to override). If ACC damage impairs multiple cognitive functions, it's not specific to cognitive control. D is tempting because equal activation seems to weaken specificity, but activation patterns in healthy brains don't necessarily reflect what happens after damage. C seems relevant but doesn't address the specificity claim.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 44
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: EASY
PROMPT: Archaeologist Nina Kowalski excavated a workshop site in southern Poland dated to the Bronze Age, approximately 1500 BCE. The workshop contained dozens of stone molds used for casting bronze tools and jewelry. Kowalski observed that the molds included designs for items that were common in both Central European and Mediterranean styles. Kowalski proposed that the workshop produced goods for long-distance trade between Central Europe and the Mediterranean world.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Kowalski's proposal?
A: The workshop contained evidence of both bronze casting and pottery production, suggesting a diversified manufacturing operation.
B: The workshop site was located near a river that archaeological evidence suggests was used as a major transportation route during the Bronze Age.
C: Other Bronze Age workshop sites in Central Europe have produced molds of similar quality and complexity to those found at Kowalski's site.
D: Chemical analysis of bronze artifacts found at archaeological sites in both Germany and coastal Greece showed that their metal composition matched tin and copper sources local to southern Poland, and the artifacts' shapes matched mold designs from Kowalski's workshop.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Kowalski claims the workshop produced goods for long-distance trade. D provides the strongest evidence: artifacts matching the workshop's molds were found FAR AWAY (Germany and Greece), and their chemical composition traces back to Polish metal sources. This proves the goods physically traveled from the workshop to distant locations. B is tempting (river = trade route) but is circumstantial -- it shows trade was possible, not that it happened.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 45
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Ecologist Petra Olsson studied wolf pack dynamics in a remote region of northern Canada. Olsson observed that pack size was positively correlated with territory size -- larger packs controlled larger territories. Olsson concluded that larger packs are more effective at defending territory against rival packs, enabling them to maintain control over greater areas.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Olsson's conclusion?
A: Wolf packs in the study region occasionally split into smaller groups during the summer months before reuniting in autumn for the hunting season.
B: Larger territories contained proportionally more prey animals per square kilometer than smaller territories, and packs in larger territories had higher reproductive rates, leading to naturally larger pack sizes over time.
C: The largest wolf pack in the study had 14 members and controlled a territory of approximately 2,500 square kilometers, while the smallest pack had 4 members and controlled 600 square kilometers.
D: Rival wolf packs were observed engaging in territorial disputes along boundary areas regardless of the size of either pack involved in the conflict.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Olsson says large packs CAUSE large territories (better defense). B suggests REVERSE CAUSATION: large territories cause large packs (more prey -> more reproduction -> bigger pack). The causal arrow may go the opposite direction. D is tricky because disputes regardless of size could mean pack size doesn't determine territorial outcomes, but it doesn't directly address why larger packs have bigger territories. Shortcut: when a correlation is interpreted as 'A causes B,' always check whether 'B causes A' is equally plausible.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 46
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Political scientist Irina Volkov analyzed data from a longitudinal study of voter behavior across three election cycles in an Eastern European country. Volkov found that voters who consumed their news primarily from social media were 25% more likely to vote for populist candidates than voters who relied primarily on traditional media sources such as newspapers and television. Volkov concluded that social media algorithms, which tend to amplify emotionally charged and sensationalized content, are a causal factor in the rise of populist support because they expose users to a disproportionate volume of populist messaging.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Volkov's conclusion?
A: Voters who consumed news from both social media and traditional media in roughly equal proportions voted for populist candidates at rates similar to those of traditional-media-only voters.
B: In a neighboring country with similar social media usage patterns, populist candidates received a declining share of the vote over the same three election cycles.
C: Analysis of the social media feeds of study participants showed that the volume and proportion of populist content in their feeds did not differ significantly from the proportion of populist content in traditional media sources during the same period.
D: Populist candidates in the study country invested more heavily in social media advertising campaigns than non-populist candidates during all three election cycles.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Volkov's causal mechanism is specific: algorithms create DISPROPORTIONATE exposure to populist messaging. C directly tests and refutes this: social media feeds contained the SAME proportion of populist content as traditional media. If there's no disproportionate exposure, the algorithm theory fails. D is a trap -- more populist advertising on social media could actually support Volkov's conclusion. A is interesting (dilution effect) but doesn't directly address whether algorithms amplify populist content.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 47
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Climatologist Ana Ribeiro studied tree-ring data from ancient bristlecone pines in the White Mountains of eastern California to reconstruct temperature patterns over the past 4,000 years. Ribeiro identified a period of unusually warm temperatures between 800 and 1100 CE, which she labeled the 'Western Medieval Warm Period.' Ribeiro proposed that this warm period was driven by increased solar irradiance rather than volcanic or ocean-current variability.

Which finding from the researchers' analysis, if true, would support Ribeiro's proposed explanation?
A: Ice-core data from Greenland showed elevated concentrations of beryllium-10, an isotope produced by solar cosmic rays, during the 800-1100 CE period, indicating higher-than-average solar activity during that interval.
B: The 800-1100 CE warm period corresponded with a period of increased agricultural productivity in medieval Europe, as documented in historical records.
C: Tree-ring data from other mountain ranges in western North America confirmed the existence of a warm period between 800 and 1100 CE.
D: A major volcanic eruption in Indonesia occurred in approximately 1258 CE, causing a documented period of global cooling that ended the Medieval Warm Period.
ANSWER: A
EXPLANATION: Trick: Ribeiro says SOLAR IRRADIANCE caused the warming. A provides independent evidence of higher solar activity during that exact time period (beryllium-10 levels in ice cores). B and C confirm the warm period existed but don't explain its CAUSE. D is about a volcanic eruption AFTER the warm period that caused cooling -- wrong time frame and wrong direction. Shortcut: when the claim is about a specific CAUSE, only evidence for that cause counts as support.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 48
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Historian Rebecca Nsiah studied records of textile production in pre-colonial Ghana and found that certain villages specialized in producing distinct types of kente cloth. Nsiah observed that villages located along major rivers produced cloth with more complex patterns than villages farther from rivers. Nsiah concluded that proximity to rivers facilitated access to a wider variety of dye-producing plants, enabling weavers in riverside villages to create more intricate and colorful designs.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the conclusion about textile production that is presented in the text?
A: Rivers in the region were important trade routes that connected villages to larger commercial centers, facilitating the exchange of weaving techniques and designs.
B: The tradition of kente weaving in Ghana has been recognized by UNESCO as an intangible cultural heritage.
C: Non-riverside villages tended to have smaller populations than riverside villages during the pre-colonial period, which may have limited the number of skilled weavers.
D: The more complex cloth patterns produced in riverside villages relied on geometric intricacy rather than color variety, and the number of distinct dye colors used was the same in both riverside and non-riverside villages.
ANSWER: D
EXPLANATION: Trick: Nsiah claims river proximity -> more dye plants -> more colorful/intricate designs. D breaks this chain: the complexity was GEOMETRIC (pattern intricacy), not COLOR-based, and dye color variety was IDENTICAL in both types of villages. If the same dyes were used everywhere, access to dye plants can't explain the difference. A is tempting because trade routes could offer an alternative explanation for complexity, but it doesn't directly contradict Nsiah's specific dye-access claim.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 49
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM
PROMPT: Immunologist Grace Oyelaran investigated why certain individuals exposed to a novel respiratory virus remained asymptomatic while others developed severe illness. Oyelaran found that asymptomatic individuals had significantly higher levels of cross-reactive T-cells -- immune cells that had been trained by previous infections with related but distinct viruses. Oyelaran proposed that these pre-existing cross-reactive T-cells provided partial immunity by recognizing and attacking the novel virus before it could establish a severe infection.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Oyelaran's proposal?
A: Several of the asymptomatic individuals had been vaccinated against influenza within the past year, while most symptomatic individuals had not been recently vaccinated.
B: In laboratory experiments, cross-reactive T-cells extracted from asymptomatic individuals were able to identify and destroy cells infected with the novel virus, while T-cells from symptomatic individuals showed no such response.
C: Asymptomatic individuals were on average younger than symptomatic individuals, and younger age is associated with stronger overall immune function.
D: The novel respiratory virus was genetically distinct from all previously known respiratory viruses, sharing less than 40% of its genome with any known virus.
ANSWER: B
EXPLANATION: Trick: Oyelaran says cross-reactive T-cells RECOGNIZE AND ATTACK the novel virus. B provides direct laboratory evidence of this: T-cells from asymptomatic individuals DID identify and destroy infected cells, while T-cells from symptomatic individuals did not. This confirms the proposed mechanism. A is tempting but vaccination produces antibodies, not necessarily the cross-reactive T-cells Oyelaran describes. C is a confound. D actually WEAKENS by suggesting cross-reactivity is unlikely.
END QUESTION

QUESTION 50
SECTION: READING_WRITING
CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)
DIFFICULTY: HARD
PROMPT: Behavioral economist Viktor Sorensen conducted a study in which participants were given $100 and asked to allocate it between a guaranteed return of 5% and a risky investment with an expected return of 12% but a 30% chance of total loss. Sorensen found that participants who completed the allocation task in a room with red walls allocated an average of 20% more to the guaranteed return compared to participants who completed the same task in a room with blue walls. Sorensen concluded that the color red triggers a psychological state of heightened caution, leading individuals to make more risk-averse financial decisions.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Sorensen's conclusion?
A: Cultural associations with the color red vary across societies, with red symbolizing luck and prosperity in several East Asian cultures.
B: In a follow-up study using rooms of identical design but different wall colors, participants in green-walled rooms made investment allocations that were not significantly different from those of participants in blue-walled rooms.
C: Participants in the red-walled room reported significantly higher levels of general discomfort and distraction due to the room's paint, which had a strong chemical smell, and these self-reported discomfort levels were correlated with more conservative investment allocations.
D: Participants in both rooms showed similar levels of skin conductance, a physiological measure of arousal, throughout the experimental session.
ANSWER: C
EXPLANATION: Trick: Sorensen says RED COLOR -> caution -> risk-averse choices. C provides an alternative explanation: the red room had a PAINT SMELL that caused discomfort, and discomfort (not color) correlated with conservative choices. The color was confounded with smell. D is tempting because similar arousal seems to undermine the 'heightened caution' claim, but skin conductance measures arousal, not caution specifically -- these are different psychological states. Shortcut: when a study blames X, check whether Y was also present and could explain the result.
END QUESTION